

was a girl, recipient of a scholar blazer at her competitive school (which means she scored over 80 per cent three years in a row), a dancer, a fan of emo music (emotional music), devoted to her cellphone—an N72—and to her Facebook and Orkut accounts. A girl, just eight days short of her 14th birthday, who had raced through all the Meg Cabots (the creator of every girl's fantasy, a suburban schoolgirl-turned-princess), who was obsessed with checking herself out in the

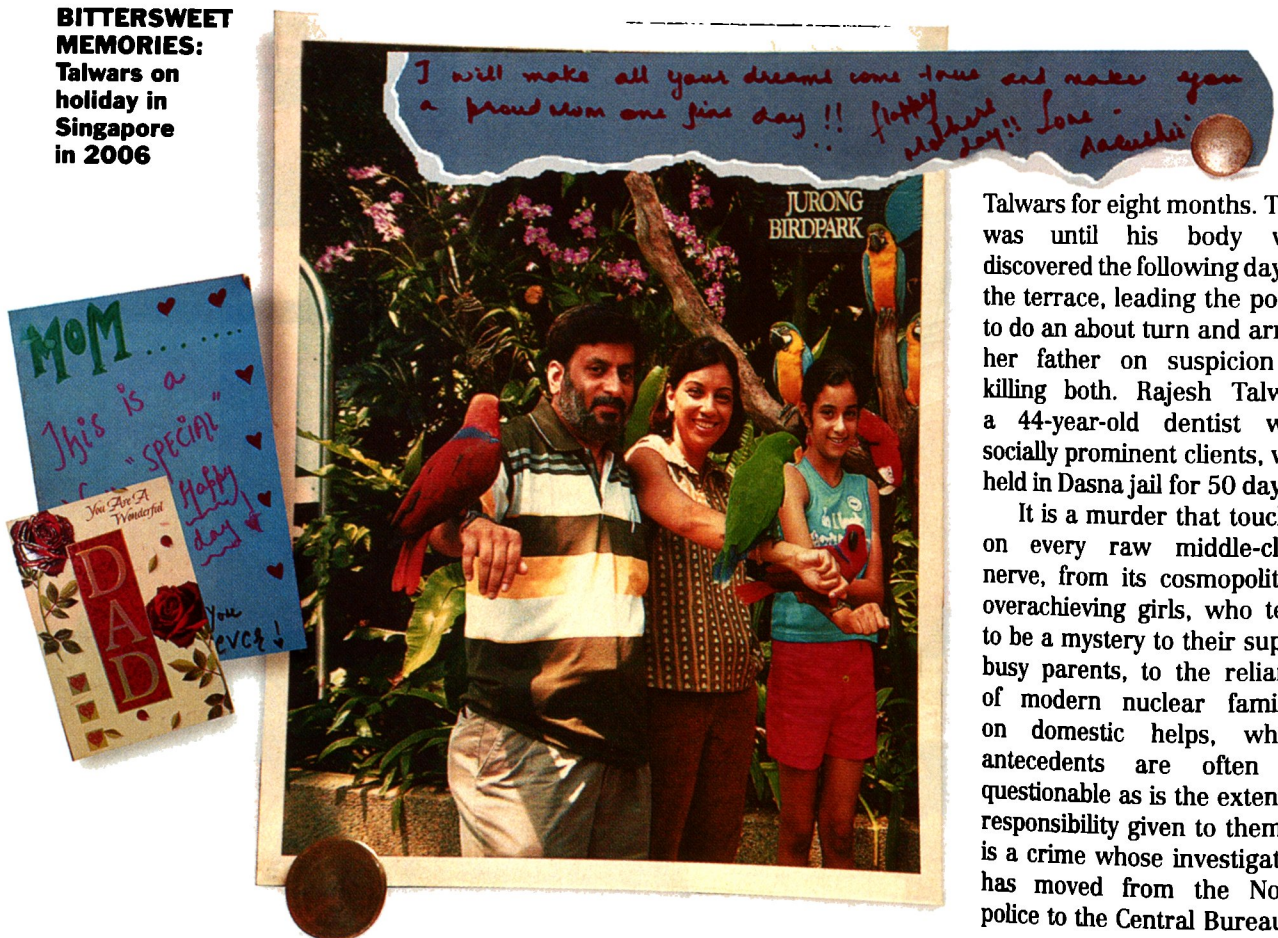
mirror, loved to watch movies with friends, whose favourite song was Colbie Caillat's *Bubbly* (whose lyrics are suitably sophomoric, *I've been awake for a while now/You've got me feeling like a child now/Cause everytime I see your bubbly face/I get the tinglies in a silly place*) and who managed to divide her time equally between her 15-year-old boyfriend, her girl gang, another set of school friends, and her parents.

In short just another teenager, terrifyingly accomplished,

and intimidatingly talented? Quite. Only now she's a byword for a gruesome crime that has torn apart polite society, and seen an incredulous nation go from blaming the father for the murder, to accusing three domestic helpers of slitting her throat, and that of the Talwars' help, Hemraj Banjade.

Aarushi was killed on the day before her summer vacations were to begin. Initially the police blamed the domestic help, Hemraj, who had been employed by the

BITTERSWEET MEMORIES:
Talwars on holiday in Singapore in 2006



Talwars for eight months. That was until his body was discovered the following day on the terrace, leading the police to do an about turn and arrest her father on suspicion of killing both. Rajesh Talwar, a 44-year-old dentist with socially prominent clients, was held in Dasna jail for 50 days.

It is a murder that touches on every raw middle-class nerve, from its cosmopolitan, overachieving girls, who tend to be a mystery to their super-busy parents, to the reliance of modern nuclear families on domestic helps, whose antecedents are often as questionable as is the extent of responsibility given to them. It is a crime whose investigation has moved from the Noida police to the Central Bureau of

BLOOD ON THE FLOOR DIARY OF A DOUBLE MURDER

MAY 16 Aarushi Talwar, daughter of a dentist couple, is found dead with her throat slit; domestic help Hemraj Banjade suspected.

MAY 17 Hemraj's decomposed body is found on the terrace of the Talwars' house.

MAY 19 Talwars' former Nepalese

domestic help Vishnu Sharma is named suspect.

MAY 23 The family is now under suspicion. The police probe a

possible honour killing. Rajesh Talwar, Aarushi's father, is held for the double murder. The inspector general of police, Meerut, Gurdarshan

